



Vanuatu

An archipelago of 82 islands and islets in the South Pacific, Vanuatu was ruled jointly by the UK and France from 1906 until independence in 1980. Politics is democratic but volatile.



GEOGRAPHY

Mountainous and volcanic, with coral beaches and dense rainforest. Cultivated land along the coasts.



CLIMATE

Tropical. Temperatures and rainfall decline from north to south.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Indigenous Melanesians form a majority. Ni-Vanuatu culture is traditional; local social and religious customs are strong, despite centuries of missionary influence. Subsistence farming and fishing are the main activities. 80% of the population lives on the 12 main islands. Women have lower social status than men and payment of bride-price is common.

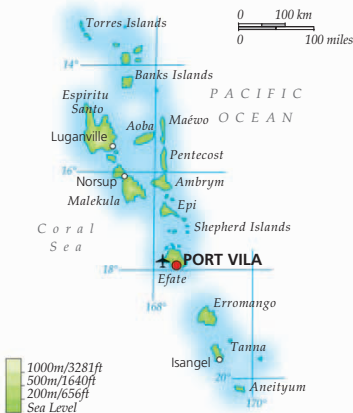


INSIGHT: With 105 indigenous tongues, Vanuatu has the world's highest per capita density of languages



THE ECONOMY

Reliant on aid. Main export is copra; diversifying into beef, timber, kava. Tourism. Offshore banking: rules tightened after international pressure.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Vanuatu

DATE OF FORMATION: 1980

CAPITAL: Port Vila

POPULATION: 239,800

TOTAL AREA: 4710 sq. miles
(12,200 sq. km)

DENSITY: 51 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bislama*, English*, French*

RELIGIONS: Presbyterian 37%, other 25%, Anglican 15%, Roman Catholic 15%, traditional beliefs 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Melanesian 98%, European 1%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Vatu = 100 centimes